

Accuse and blame

Teaching guide

Distinguish an allegation from an assignment of responsibility.

Understand the distinction

Accuse someone of something means say that the person did something wrong: accuse someone of lying. Blame someone for something assigns responsibility: blame the supplier for a delay.

An accusation is a claim, not proof. Use alleged, said, or according to when reporting an unestablished claim. In a practical discussion, describing an observed problem and asking for an explanation can be more useful than assigning blame.

Compare the patterns

ACCUSE OF

They accused him of sharing the file.

They claimed he did something wrong.

BLAME FOR

They blamed the delay on a missed delivery.

This assigns a cause.

OBSERVE

The file arrived after the deadline.

This states an observable event.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: She accused him ___ copying.

2. Complete: They blamed me ___ the mistake.

3. Does was accused of prove that someone did it?

Use it in your own life

Rewrite an accusation as a factual observation and a question.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. of

The pattern is accuse someone of something.

2. for

Use blame someone for something.

3. No. It reports an allegation.

Keep the distinction between a claim and an established fact.

One possible response

The report arrived after the deadline. What caused the delay?

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-24.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Rewrite an accusation as a factual observation and a question.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.